Adapt and Support Extend and Challenge

Responding to different needs

Use Adapt & Support and Extend & Challenge when responses show different needs. Keep the learning goal ambitious while adjusting the support or depth of the next task.

How to do it well

1 Read the pattern. Identify which students need a prompt, a re-model or more guided practice and which are ready for deeper application.

2 Locate the barrier. Check whether the issue concerns knowledge, vocabulary, task structure or a specific decision.

3 Select the smallest support. Give a useful cue, model, frame or short teacher group while retaining the curricular goal.

4 Extend the secure learning. Use explanation, variation or a less familiar case that requires additional thinking.

5 Hand back responsibility. Remove support as competence becomes visible and use independent responses to decide the next adjustment.

What this sounds like

“If you need the first-step prompt, use it for this example. If your method is secure, explain how the answer changes when this condition changes.”

Classroom example. In Science, some pupils need a prompt to select the relationship while others can justify it independently. A short teacher group rehearses the first decision; secure pupils explore how a changed condition affects the result. All work remains connected to the same concept, and the temporary support is removed when students can proceed alone.

Top tips that make the technique work

Diagnose before grouping. The same incorrect answer can come from different barriers; a quick probe may change the support needed.

Use flexible groups. Group briefly by the current learning need, then release students when they can proceed independently.

Extend through depth. Ask for justification, a boundary case or transfer rather than simply more identical questions.

Preserve a common thread. Students should remain working on the intended knowledge even when support differs.

Return to independent evidence. A successful response beside the teacher may depend on prompts; check what the student can do alone.

Do and avoid

Do	Avoid
Adjust support to the observed barrier.	Permanent task assignment by label or prior attainment.
Provide meaningful challenge for secure students.	Giving different groups unrelated learning goals.

Further reading

Practitioner guidance; teacher language above is an illustrative BSCS adaptation.

DistillED - Adaptive Teaching | Barton - A model for responsive teaching